

» RISING STAR
KRISHNA JAYASANKAR



A LASS IN VEGAS

Krishna Jayasankar is now the **first Indian** woman to compete in the NCAA finals.

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It's rare for a 23-year-old to stay away from social media for as long as she has, but a few weeks ago, Krishna Jayasankar Menon finally opened an *Instagram* account in her name. And, she's already receiving plenty of messages — for good reason.

On June 14, with her opening throw in the women's discus at the NCAA (National Collegiate Athletic Association)

Championships, the 23-year-old etched her name into Indian sporting history. Representing the University of Nevada, Las Vegas (UNLV), she became the first Indian woman to compete in the final of the NCAA Track and Field Championships — the premier collegiate athletics competition in the United States and widely regarded as the highest level of college sport worldwide.

Another Indian, Sharvari Parulekar, also matched Krishna's milestone of competing in the NCAA finals and became the second Indian woman to do so. She took part in the women's triple jump in Oregon, just about half an hour after Krishna's event.

While the number of Indian athletes competing in the NCAA has been growing in recent years, there are still only a handful who have competed at its highest level. Krishna and Sharvari are just the fifth and sixth Indian track and field athletes ever to make the NCAA finals, following the likes of Mohinder Gill, Vikas Gowda, Tejaswin Shankar and Lokesh Sathyanathan.

As the clock ticked down to her event, Krishna was raring to go. "I

Giant strides: Competing in a strong field, Krishna made a throw of 52.99m to take 18th place in the NCAA finals.

Pics: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT